BUILDING MENTAL FLEXIBILITY

Model flexibility in daily life

What to do:	What to say:
Share your thoughts aloud when you are problem solving or adapting to an unexpected situation	"Hmm, the store is closed right now... maybe we could come back tonight before dinner, or we could wait to go this weekend"
Model coping with disappointment	"I'm so sad that it is raining and we can't go to the beach like we planned. I'm going to take a few deep breaths and put on a song I like to help me feel better"
Help your child learn to resolve their conflicts through problem solving	"Ok, I see you want the toy your sister has. How could we fix this? You could take turns, or play together, or both choose other toys... what do you think?"





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YOUNG CHILD PARENTING GROUP AT MGH

ADAPTED FROM THE MOM POWER VIRTUAL GROUP CURRICULUM (MUZIK & ROSENBLUM ET AL., UNPUBLISHED MANUAL, 2021)

BUILDING MENTAL FLEXIBILITY

In moments when your child is struggling to be mentally flexible:

Validate their feelings

"I know it's disappointing that your favorite shirt is dirty and you can't wear it today. You really wanted to wear it."

Praise moments of flexibility

"I know it was disappointing to not wear your favorite shirt – I'm proud of you for picking out this other one instead! Good job practicing being flexible"

Offer support

Give them space to feel their feelings and remain as calm as you can

"When you're ready, I'm here to help you. Maybe your cozy dino shirt or your new shirt with stripes would feel good to wear too"







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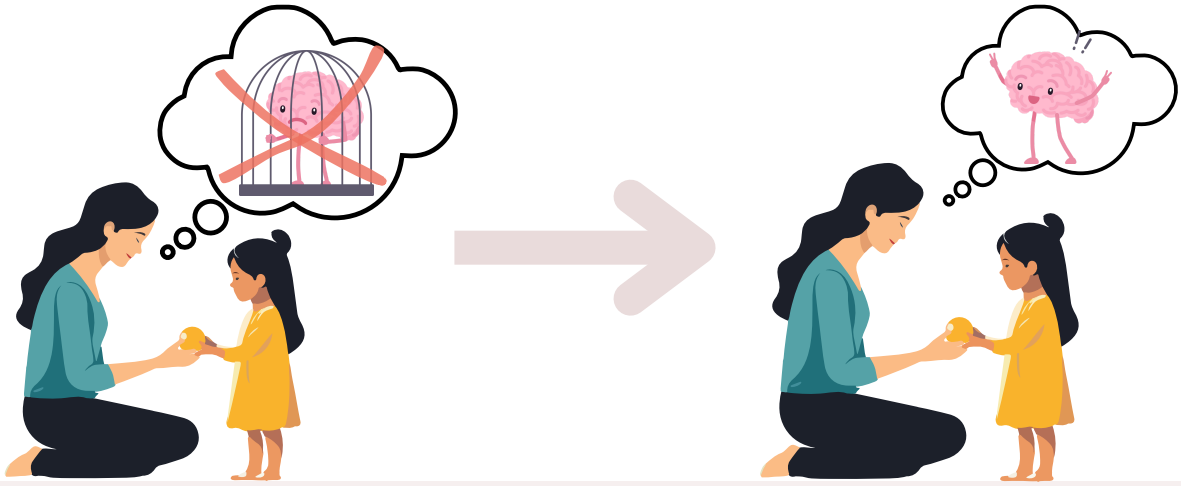
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BUILDING MENTAL FLEXIBILITY

PRACTICE FLEXIBLE THINKING

Bend the rules: change the rules of Uno/another board or card game, put socks on before underwear, eat spaghetti using a spoon, etc

- Make it more like a game to increase engagement: flipping a coin, pulling an idea from a jar of "choices", etc
- Reinforce with lots of praise
- Consider implementing a prize system for a month or so to help build the "habit" of being flexible
- Consider telling them they've "leveled up" to other flexibility challenges over time



PRACTICE FLEXIBLE THINKING

Read books about mental flexibility

- Examples include: Adaptable Ninja by Mary Nhin, Bubble Gum Brain by Julia Cook, What Should Danny Do by Ganit & Adir Levy

Encourage activities and games that require mental flexibility

- Imaginary play, obstacle courses, board games, “fortunately/unfortunately” storytelling game